

Will Racism Combat Terrorism?

THE security situation in Colombo has been causing increasing alarm. A parallel and equally unpleasant development is the institution of practices which discriminate against Tamils, notably in respect of employment and housing, but frequently also in respect of mere presence in public places. These practices not only violate basic human rights if Tamils but also have dangerous implications for Sri Lanka.

Most non-Tamils may not be fully aware of these racially discriminatory practices or of their implications. Unemployment is a problem which affects members of all communities, but Tamils who have been seeking employment are often told that they cannot be considered for employment on account of their ethnicity. Young Tamils, especially males are those worst affected. Even Tamils who are in employment, particularly in the private sector, feel very insecure. Several have lost their jobs on account of a single unsubstantiated anonymous petition. So long as there are indiscriminate arrests and detentions of Tamils and harassment of their employers, such racial

discrimination will continue.

The racial discrimination in respect of housing is as pervasive or worse than in respect of employment. Again, most non-Tamils may not be fully aware of this, but Tamils who have been looking for housing quickly discover that many houses, apartments and, in particular, lodgings are not available to them and that many others are offered to them at rents much higher than to non-Tamils. Even Tamils who had found accommodation have been harassed by the police and neighbours and evicted on account of unsubstantiated anonymous petitions. In effect, there are two racially differentiated housing markets: the one for Tamils is significantly smaller, substantially higher priced and with less secure tenure than the one for non-Tamils. This is an unavoidable consequence of indiscriminate harassment of Tamils and of the owners of their houses/apartments or of the chief occupants of their lodgings.

What is most unfortunate is that such blatant racial discrimination, which is contrary to the liberal and non-racist traditions of Sri

Lanka, is aggravated not only because of the incidence of terrorism but also by measures adopted by state agencies to combat it. The repeated exhortations to report on all suspicious-looking people, without any caution against inconveniencing or discriminating against innocent persons, inevitably results in reports against virtually all Tamils. In this situation, ill-will flourishes in multi-ethnic neighbourhoods. Racist practices such as requiring all Tamils (and Tamils only) to register their residence, including temporary residence, with the Police Station through the owners of their houses/apartments or the chief occupants of their lodgings make a bad situation worse.

Racial discrimination and giving official sanction are utterly reprehensible; the ill-effects of these developments go even further. Many Tamils, particularly young males, have come out of the North or East to escape the conditions there; others have opted to remain outside the North or East; yet others have chosen to return to Sri Lanka from overseas. If they continue to face discrimination in respect of employment and housing and to encounter

constant harassment, they may have no option but to return to the North or East and to accept the rules of life in that region. Even young Tamils long settled outside the North or East may be induced to go to the North or East if they find that they are not welcome elsewhere. This will promote not only racial segregation but also bitterness among those driven away on account of racial discrimination.

Some of those interested in human rights and national unity have taken up individual cases of Tamils who have been victims of racial discrimination. It does not appear that the broader policies and practices of racial discrimination and their implications for national unity have been publicly addressed. The security situation in many areas outside the North and East is indeed a matter of grave concern to all of us. But the remedy must cure, and not aggravate the illness. To seek to deal with acts of terrorism through racially discriminatory policies and practices is not merely morally flawed; such an approach is shortsighted and counter-productive in respect of national unity and security. ■

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Let's say **NO** to Corporal Punishment

I very much appreciate the contents of the article but at the same time wish to state that teachers should not be alone blamed for the discipline of children, and further it is not really acceptable to do away with corporate punishment completely for the following reasons :

A child's behaviour is moulded from the infant stage. From the article it is seen that Mr. N.Y. Cassie Chetty, the new Head Master of St. Thomas College has not been subjected to corporal punishment at home or at school. He is lucky that he had good, understanding and well educated parents. I am definite he had been educated in a good school and also by a good set of teachers. This is not so for everyone. I am of the opinion that 90% of children's behaviour depends on their being brought up by their parents and only 10% by his or her teachers. A parent at the most has to look-after not more than 06 children in extreme cases, and the children spend about 16 hours a day with their parents and only 8 hours a day with a teacher. Nowadays a teacher will have to look after 40 students for approximately 40 minutes for each subject. With this the teacher will have to teach the students, correct exercise books and look-

after their well-being. Therefore it will be extremely difficult for the teacher to concentrate on all students equally and also leisurely.

In Sri Lanka though each and every parent wants his or her child to be of very good behaviour and do well in life, are they contributing towards this genuinely? It is true that, psychologists say that high delinquency rate, dropping out of schools, result from violations of the self of children through various cases or types of violent abuses mild or strong. It is very easy to say this, but very difficult to implement. The concerned parent has brought out a case of a small child completely afraid of the teacher and it is very unfortunate that there are many cases like this. I am stating another extreme case that happened to a friend's son. He is also studying in a reputed school. In this case he had been harassed or hit by another student and when he reported this to the teacher the class teacher not only did not take any action against the student but has threatened that she will not give stars for progress in class work if there is any complaint. Don't you think by this the teacher is encouraging one student to do all sorts of harassing etc. and not taking any action to correct it? Maybe, the teacher did

not want to do it or the teacher is afraid to do this. This is only one side of the picture concerning what is happening in the so-called well known private schools. Have we ever looked into the other schools which are about 75% of the total number? In these schools children of various types of backgrounds are studying. Even the staff in do not have proper facilities. With this the poor teacher had to teach the students and also compete with the well endowed schools to produce results and compete in all activities including discipline. Further, I wish to state that these students are with the teacher at most from 6 to 8 hours for only about 170 days a year. The other days go as public holidays and term holidays. If the parents spend at least one hour with their children personally every day, out of the 16 hours they are with them, they can produce far better results. Thus, because the children are at home it does not mean that they are looked after by parents. About indiscipline I will state the parents are to take more responsibility than the teacher though many may not wish for this. I would say that we as parents contribute to the present state of indiscipline etc. by the students even at the University level.

When a set of students

are ragged at the University at the extreme of sadism and also to damage the respect of the individual, as parents are we to encourage or condemn? It is very sad that some of the parents are keen on getting the culprit exonerated while they are not bothering at all with what has happened at the varsity and it is a fact that it is due to lack of discipline. Some parents give too many facilities to their children and a few children join them and go on the wrong track like smoking, drugs etc. which may not be possible for children of normal families. Further, some of us try to insist that our children ways do the correct thing and never try to advise them. Therefore, my view is that the abolishment of corporal punishment should not be taken as sufficient by itself. But it is necessary at least in some cases in schools. It may be in few schools like St. Thomas' College this may be possible to manage without corporal punishment. In other schools unless the parents take a big share and interest it may not be possible at all to abolish corporal punishment and as such corporal punishment will be inevitable. ■

Another Concerned Parent